

Azure Databricks Jobs and Pipelines can absolutely be used. For many Databricks-only projects, you **do not need Apache Airflow**.

Think of it like this:

Tool	Best when
Databricks Jobs	You want to schedule notebooks, Python scripts, Spark jobs, SQL tasks inside Databricks
Databricks Workflows	You want multiple Databricks tasks connected together
Delta Live Tables / Lakeflow Declarative Pipelines	You want managed ETL pipelines inside Databricks with bronze/silver/gold tables
Apache Airflow	You want to orchestrate jobs across many systems, not just Databricks

Simple answer

Airflow is not exactly an alternative to Databricks.

It is more like an **external orchestrator**.

Databricks is the **execution platform**.

Airflow is the **traffic controller**.

Example: only Databricks needed

Suppose your flow is:

```
Read CSV from ADLS
↓
Clean using PySpark notebook
↓
Write Delta table
↓
Run another notebook
↓
Schedule daily
```

Use **Databricks Jobs / Workflows**. No need for Airflow.

Example: Airflow becomes useful

Suppose your flow is:

```
Check if file arrived in SFTP
↓
Call an API
↓
Trigger Azure Databricks notebook
↓
Run Azure Data Factory pipeline
↓
Load data into Snowflake
↓
Send Slack/Email alert
↓
Trigger Power BI refresh
```

Now Airflow makes more sense because it can coordinate many external systems.

Databricks Jobs vs Airflow

Feature	Databricks Jobs	Apache Airflow
Runs Databricks notebooks	Yes	Yes, by triggering Databricks
Runs Spark jobs	Yes	Yes, indirectly
Good for Databricks-only workflows	Excellent	Overkill
Good for multi-system orchestration	Limited compared to Airflow	Excellent
UI monitoring	Yes	Yes
Retry support	Yes	Yes
DAG-style dependencies	Yes	Yes
Cloud/platform independent	No, Databricks-focused	Yes
Best role	Run/manage Databricks workloads	Orchestrate across platforms